

Captain onboarding: where we lose them, and what to do

To: Head of Supply From: Data Science, Captain Acquisition Date: 30 June 2026 Basis: 22,561 signups from 1 January to 15 June 2026, about 4,140 a month. Later signups are left out because they have not had time to finish onboarding yet.

BOTTOM LINE

- **We approve 17.6% of signups — 728 captains a month — and 98.7% of those go on to take a first order.** Acquisition-to-Onboarded is the constraint; Registered-to-Active looks after itself. Onboarding is the only place worth spending.
- **Nine in ten captains who don't finish were never rejected. They stopped.** Only 1.3% ran out of their three allowed attempts. This is friction we control, not policy we have to accept.
- **Fixing how captains photograph their documents, and chasing the ones who stall, is worth 183 to 344 more approved captains a month** — a quarter to a half again on top of today's 728, with no extra acquisition spend.

Two claims currently in circulation do not survive checking. The WhatsApp campaign CAMP_WA_002 is not an 18-point win, and the airport does not need more captains.

WHERE THE VOLUME GOES

The loss is spread across all six documents, but not evenly. **The Registration Certificate is the worst step in the business:** 17% of submissions fail there, which costs us about 1,000 captains a month and accounts for 30% of everything we lose. Insurance is second at 18%, and hurts more, because those captains had already cleared everything else. *(Full stage-by-stage numbers on slide 2.)*

THE BIGGEST FIXABLE LEAK

Cheap phones do not fail verification across the board. They fail on exactly three documents.

Submissions rejected for an unreadable photo	Basic phone	Premium phone
Registration Certificate, Fitness, Insurance	28.1%	7.9%
Driving Licence, Aadhaar, Permit	5.5%	5.9%

The three affected documents are the full-page paper ones covered in small print. The three unaffected ones are pocket-sized laminated cards. A basic phone camera photographs a card perfectly well and a full sheet of paper badly. Nearly half our signups — 46% — are on basic handsets, so this is not a niche segment.

Two things make this worth fixing rather than merely noting. **Captains who try again mostly get through** — 79% eventually pass the Registration Certificate. And **the rejection message we send is doing no work at all:** captains try again about 62% of the time regardless of which of the seven reasons they were given. "Blurred photo" and "document expired" produce identical behaviour, even though one is a thirty-second fix and the other means they cannot proceed at all.

RECOMMENDATIONS, RANKED

- 1. Rebuild document capture in the app for the three full-page documents.** Take the photo automatically once the page edges are in frame, check it for blur and glare on the handset, and show the captain an example of a good one. Tell them in two seconds on the phone, not eight hours later from the back office. *Worth 81 to 134 more approvals a month. One product squad, about six weeks. Risk: the very oldest cameras may not be good enough, in which case we need captains to be able to submit at a partner store instead. Watch the unreadable-photo rejection rate on those three documents, split by handset type.*
- 2. Go after the captains who stalled between documents.** 9,727 of them passed one document and never started the next, and slightly over half go on to be approved if they come back. Start with the 2,500 who cleared everything except Insurance. Insurance costs a captain real money, so send the reminder alongside a financed or partner insurance offer rather than a reminder on its own. *Worth 90 to 181 more approvals a month. Needs CRM plus one insurance partnership. Keep a fifth of them off the reminder list from day one, so we can tell what the reminder actually did.*
- 3. Judge acquisition channels on the orders they deliver, not the approvals.** Paid digital converts 10.0% of its signups against 26.7% for field sales — but approval rate is the wrong yardstick, because field-sourced captains approve best and then complete the fewest orders. Counting orders delivered per 100 signups, referral (579) and field sales (570) are worth double paid digital (290). Move half the paid digital budget to referral. *Worth about 18 more approvals a month and materially more orders. Cheapest of the three to start.*

CAMP_WA_002 DOES NOT JUSTIFY A 5X BUDGET

Captains who got the message are approved at 29.2% against 11.2% for everyone else, which looks like an 18-point win. But **the message only goes out once a captain has already cleared two documents.** None of the 7,981 recipients received it any earlier. Getting through the Licence and the Registration Certificate is where 44% of all our loss happens — so the recipient list is, by construction, a list of captains who had already survived the worst of the funnel. The campaign is a consequence of progress, not a cause of it.

Comparing the same captains more fairly	Apparent gain
Everyone who got it against everyone who didn't <i>(the claim)</i>	17.9 points
Only against captains who had also cleared two documents	4.2 points
...and who were still active at the moment it went out	3.7 points
...and allowing for city, vehicle, channel and handset	3.8 points

Four-fifths of the claimed effect is simply who was on the list. The remainder is doubtful too: captains whose message **failed to send** were approved at 31.8%, against 31.5% for those who received it, and captains who tapped the message did no better than those who ignored it. A message has to arrive and be read to change anything, and neither shows up in the numbers. **The number I would put my name on is "3.8 points at the very most, and quite possibly nothing."** The honest range sits between 2 and 5 points, and I would not spend against the top of it.

A 5x budget is also arithmetically impossible. The campaign already reaches 55% of every captain who becomes eligible for it, so covering all of them is less than double the current volume. Spending five times as much means sending it to captains who have not cleared two documents — where it has never been tried, and where most of our loss actually is. Do extend it to the remaining 1,200 eligible captains a month, since WhatsApp costs us almost nothing. But hold 20% of them back as a comparison group, so that in six months we can finally state what it does. We have been running it for six months already and still cannot.

AIRPORT: DO NOT FUND THE ACQUISITION PUSH

The airport is not short of captains. It is short of captains for eight hours a day. The terminals serve 59.8% of the rides requested, against 96–97% everywhere else in the city, so the problem is real. But **86% of that shortfall happens between 8pm and 4am.** At midday there are 63 captains sitting at the terminals waiting on 23 requests an hour. Across May and June the terminals had **48,720 captain-hours going spare in the hours they were already covered, against a shortfall of 17,979 captain-hours in the hours they were not** — three times more waste than shortage. One extra captain online at night converts into 1.31 extra completed rides an hour. The same captain at midday adds 0.19.

Acquisition buys us headcount. It cannot buy us hours. Nothing in this data connects where a captain lives to whether they will work at 2am — the airport files carry no captain identity at all, so the premise behind the proposal cannot be tested, let alone supported.

More captains would also make worse the very thing keeping them away. Four in ten airport trips end in a suburb 23 km out, where the captain's chance of picking up another fare within twenty minutes is 17%, against 53% for a city-centre drop. Captains turn down 21.0% of the suburban airport trips they are offered, against 8.6% of the city ones — and across the five drop zones, the more likely a destination is to leave a captain empty, the more reliably they refuse it. The relationship is almost exact. Counting the driving out, the waiting and the empty drive back, that suburban run pays a captain about ₹176 for each hour it ties them up, against ₹263 for a city drop. Captains are not unwilling to work. They are declining one specific bad trip — and roughly a quarter of the airport demand we record as unmet is a captain who accepted and then cancelled.

What I would do instead. (a) Pay our existing captains to work the terminals between 8pm and 4am. An extra 96 to 160 captain-hours a night recovers 232 to 387 rides a day, for ₹2.9 to ₹7.2 lakh a month — ₹41 to ₹62 for each additional ride, against an average airport fare of ₹279. This can be live within days. Run it at one terminal and not the other for the first fortnight, so we can see whether we are creating hours or just moving them from other zones. (b) Promise any captain who takes a suburban airport drop a guaranteed ride waiting when they get back to the terminal. This costs no incentive budget, because it hands out demand that is currently going unserved anyway, and it takes that trip from ₹176 to ₹216 for each hour it occupies them. (c) Do not simply pay a bonus on every suburban drop. I costed it: it works out at nine to twelve times the fare for each extra ride we actually gain, because most of the money goes to captains who would have accepted anyway.

Come back to acquisition only if night supply is still short after both. I would rather ask the 4,000 captains we already have to work different hours than recruit new ones to cover hours we have covered three times over.

WHAT I ASSUMED, AND WHAT WOULD CHANGE MY ANSWER

- **Who counts as a signup.** The longest anyone has taken to reach a decision is 14 days, so I only counted signups up to 15 June. Including June's unfinished ones would report our approval rate as 16.8% rather than 17.6% — a 0.8-point error caused purely by measuring people who have not finished. *If some group takes longer than 14 days in a way I cannot see, my figure is slightly flattering.*
- **I counted document progress from the raw event history, not from the summary field in the approvals extract.** That field overstates how far 1.8% of captains actually got, always in the same direction. Anyone reading it will get a rosier picture than reality. Separately, E-Rickshaw captains need five documents rather than six, since they need no Permit — treating everyone as needing six would wrongly mark all 4,756 of them as failures.
- **The paper-versus-card explanation is my reading, not something the data states.** The pattern itself is not in doubt. The cause is inferred. *If the real driver is something else that happens to travel with those three documents, the capture fix will underdeliver — and we would see that within two weeks of shipping it.*
- **How many stalled captains we win back is a judgement, not a measurement.** How many are stuck, and how often people in their position go on to be approved, are both measured. The share we recover is not. Treat 183–344 as the size of the prize, not a forecast.
- **Airport fares in this data do not include surge.** A fare is a flat ₹38 plus ₹13.49 a kilometre, even though the same records show surge averaging around double at night. So every earnings figure above is a floor. *If captains genuinely are paid roughly double at night and still avoid the airport, the empty-return-trip problem is worse than I have described and the case against acquisition only gets stronger.*
- **The airport trip file is a two-thirds sample,** so any total I have drawn from it is scaled up and flagged as an estimate. And 457 message records show a captain tapping a message that was never delivered to them, so I have not used tap-through rates anywhere.

What I chose not to do. No activation or retention work, because 98.7% of approved captains already start driving. No project to speed up verification: captains whose documents were checked within two hours carried on at exactly the same rate as those who waited more than a day (84.0% against 84.1%), so the queue is not what is stopping them. And no city-by-city programme — our best and worst cities are 2.9 points apart, against 8.8 points between handset types and 16.7 points between acquisition channels.